Subject-Verb Agreement

"The term 'subject-verb agreement', just like the name suggests, refers to the agreement between the subject and the verb.

This is mainly with reference to singular and plural nouns/pronouns that act as subjects.

1. Basic Rule:

Singular Subjects and Singular Verbs: Make sure that when referring to an individual, use a singular verb.

Example:

- Vishnu always completes his reports on time.
- The manager is in a meeting.

Plural Subjects and Plural Verbs: When talking about multiple individuals, use a plural verb.

Example:

- Sarah and Nancy lead the marketing team.

2. Compound Subjects:

When two or more people are involved, ensure the verb matches. i.e. if two subjects are joined by "and," use a plural verb.

Example:

- Vishnu and Irfan attend the weekly meetings.
- Jenny and Mark are attending the conference.

If two subjects are joined by "or" or "nor," the verb agrees with the closer subject.

Example:

- Neither the manager nor the team is available.
- Either the client or the marketing department is responsible for providing the campaign brief

3. Indefinite Pronouns:

Indefinite pronouns like "everyone," "someone," and "each" take singular verbs.

Example:

- Everyone has submitted their reports.
- Each student has been asked to provide a consent letter.

Pronouns like "both," "few," and "many" take plural verbs.

Example:

- Many of the employees are attending the training.

4. Collective nouns

Some examples are "group," "team," "committee," "family," and "class."

Example:

- The group meets every week.
- The committee agrees on the quality of the writing.
- The board of directors approves the new budget.
- The team is in agreement.
- The jury has reached a verdict.
- The Department of Finance is conducting an audit.

However, the plural verb is used if the focus is on the individuals in the group. This is much less common.

Example:

- The committee participate in various volunteer activities in their private lives. (less common)
- The team are discussing different options. (less common)

5. Subjects Intervened by Phrases: Ignore Intervening Phrases focus on the subject

Examples

- The list of tasks, as well as the schedule, was reviewed.
- The new project proposal, along with several supplementary documents, has been submitted for approval

6. Tricky Cases:

Closely observe these sentences and absorb the usage.

- There/here are many opportunities for growth.
- There is only one vacancy available in the company.
- Irfan, along with his team, is presenting at the conference.
- Ten percent of the budget is allocated for research.
- 1267 kilometres is too long for us to travel in half a day.
- 10 years is not considered optimum to go on the water slide.
- Don't you think 1000 rupees is a little too much for a portrait?
- All my dresses have become tight.
- A lot of food is left out.

Some More Tricky Cases:

- Some of the books are torn and damaged.
- Every teacher, parent and student is expected to work together.
- I wish I were a bird.
- If you were here, I would not be sad.
- We request that everyone make their choices now.